

Session 15: Treasure in Heaven

Key Takeaways

- The word *thesauros*, often translated as “treasure,” means “stored goods” and represents whatever possessions we amass to make ourselves feel safe against an unknown future.
- The good eye and bad eye are metaphors for generosity and stinginess, respectively.
- Jesus does not tell his followers not to store up; instead, he tells them to put their storing-up energy into the things of God’s Kingdom rather than the apparent security of wealth.
- The word *mamonas* in Matthew 6:24 is rather unique and may be derived from the word *amen*, giving it the sense of “a thing that secures our trust.”

Loving God & Neighbor

We here enter the third and final part of the middle movement of the Sermon on the Mount. Jesus moves on to explore what this “new covenant righteousness” will look like when it comes to the day-to-day matters of life. Specifically how we deal with money, possessions, and anxiety over our wellbeing (6:19-34), and how we relate to other people and God when we have conflicts (7:1-11), which is then summarized in the famous “Golden Rule” (7:12). There is a forward symmetry at work in the rhetorical design of 6:19-7:12 that groups all of the smaller sayings into three parts.

Matthew 6:19-21

Don’t store up treasures on the land, but in the sky (μή + imperative)

- The inverted nature of treasure on the land or in the sky

Matthew 6:22-23

Parable about two eyes: the clear eye or the bad eye

Matthew 6:24

Parable about two masters: God or *mammon* / wealth

Matthew 6:25-34

Longer teaching about trusting the heavenly Father

- 6:26, 30 **“how much more”** (πολλῷ μᾶλλον) will your Father care for you

Matthew 7:1-2

Don't condemn, so that you are not condemned (μὴ + imperative)

- The inverted nature of judgment in relationships

Matthew 7:3-5

Parable about the eye: the speck and the beam in the eye

Matthew 7:6

Parable about two kinds: holy-pearls and dog-pigs

Matthew 7:7-11

Longer teaching about trusting the heavenly Father

- **7:11** **"how much more"** (πόσω μᾶλλον) will your Father give good things to you

Matthew 7:12

Do to people what you desire them to do to you (imperative)

- The inverted nature of the golden rule: "This is the Torah and Prophets" (link back to 6:17-20)

Matthew 6:9-7:12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

There are nine total literary units in this final section, arranged in a triad that progresses in a pattern of 4+4+1.

- 6:19-34 is focused on the disciples' relationship with wealth, consisting of three short units and a longer conclusion: (a) a short opening general exhortation (6:19-21), (b) two short parables (6:22-23 and 6:24), and (c) a longer closing exhortation to trust the heavenly Father's generosity (6:25-34).
- 7:1-11 is focused on the disciples' relationships to each other, also consisting of three short units and a longer conclusion: (a) a short general exhortation (7:1), (b) two short parables (7:3-5 and 7:6), and (c) a longer closing exhortation to trust in the heavenly Father's care (7:7-11).
- 7:12 is a fitting conclusion to 7:1-11, as it focuses on personal relationships but it also functions as the conclusion of all of 5:17-7:12, linking back to the greater theme of fulfilling the Torah and the Prophets.

However, when we focus in on the internal design of each of these smaller parts, we see a clear pattern emerging. (The following points develop the insights of Dale Allison, "[The Configuration of the Sermon on the Mount and its Meaning](#)," p. 187-195.)

- A - 6:19-24 consists of three shorter units about wealth, each designed with strong antithetical contrasts: two treasures, two eyes, and two masters.
 - 6:19-21: Treasure on the land vs. treasure in heaven: "Don't store up treasure on the land, but store up treasure in heaven."
 - 6:22-23: The generous eye vs. the evil eye: "If your eye is whole there's light, but if your eye is bad, there's darkness."

- 6:24: God vs. Mammon: “You cannot serve two masters, both God and Mammon.”
- B - 6:25-34 is a concluding exhortation that follows from the previous three units. If the disciples are going to share more generously, this will create a scenario where dependence upon God’s fatherly care will become more necessary. Notice the six-fold repetition of the keyword “anxiety” (Greek: *merimnao* / *μεριμναω*), three of which are a negative imperative, “do not worry” (Greek: *μη μεριμνατε*, 6:25, 31, 34).
- A’ - 7:1-6 also consists of three shorter units about relational dynamics among the disciples, each designed with strong contrast-inversions and keywords that match the three shorter units in 6:19-24.
 - 7:1-2: Do not judge or you will be judged: The judgment by which you judge is the judgment by which you will be judged.
 - 7:3-5: The beam vs. the speck in the eye: Take out the beam in your own eye before you take out the speck in your brother’s eye.
 - 7:6: Holy-pearls vs. dogs-pigs: Don’t give what is holy-pearls to dogs-pigs who will hurt you.
- B’ - 7:7-11 is a conclusion exhortation that follows from the previous three units. If the disciples are going to sometimes withhold judgment of others’ behavior, but then other times engage in judgment, one will need discernment and wisdom, which requires trust in God’s fatherly generosity. Notice the six-fold repetition of the keywords “ask,” “seek,” and “knock.”

The two longer conclusions, 6:25-34 and 7:7-11 have many important parallel relationships.

- They both argue from the lesser to the greater, using similar vocabulary:
 - 6:25-34: “But if (εἰ δὲ) God so clothes the grass of the field ... will he not much more (οὐ πολλῷ μᾶλλον) clothe you?” (6:30).
 - 7:11: “Therefore if (εἰ οὖν) you, who are bad, know how to give good gifts ... how much more (πόσῳ μᾶλλον) will your heavenly Father give good things?”
- Both paragraphs have been built around thematic keywords, repeated six times in groups of three:
 - 6:25-34 repeats “anxiety” (*μεριμναω*) 6 times (6:25, 27, 28, 31, 34); three times as a negative imperative, “do not be anxious” (6:25, 31, 34).
 - 7:7-11 repeats the three words “ask, seek, knock” two times each, for a total of six repetitions.
- Both use twin-parable illustrations: the birds of the air and the lilies of the field / the son who asks for bread and the son who asks for a fish.
- Both units develop naturally from the logic of the three preceding units:
 - 6:25-34 focuses on the trust in God’s fatherly care that becomes necessary if one follows Jesus’ challenges about money, generosity, and Mammon in 6:19-24.
 - 7:7-11 focuses on the trust in God’s generosity that becomes necessary if one is to follow Jesus’ challenges about using discernment in relational conflicts.

When we consolidate all of these observations, we see that 6:19-7:12 has been carefully designed as two parallel panels with matching parts:

Matthew 6:19-34	Matthew 7:1-11
Matt. 6:19-21 Prohibition: "Don't store up treasure ... " Inversion: Treasure on the land vs. the skies	Matt. 7:1-2 Prohibition: "Don't judge ... " Inversion: You judge and will be judged
Matt. 6:22-23 Parable about the eye: "the eye ... your eye ... your eye ... "	Matt. 7:3-5 Parable about the eye: "the eye ... your eye ... your eye ... "
Matt. 6:24 Parable about incompatible loyalties; God vs. wealth	Matt. 7:6 Parable about incompatible; holy-pearls vs. dogs-pigs
Matt. 6:25-34 The heavenly Father's care: • "anxious" repeated 6 times • "If ... how much more ... " (6:30) • "Who among you" (6:27) • "Your heavenly father knows ... " (6:32) • "they seek ... you should seek" (6:32-33)	Matt. 7:7-11 The heavenly Father's care: • "ask/seek/knock" repeated 6 times • "If ... how much more ... " (7:11) • "Who among you" (7:9) • "Your father in heaven knows ..." (7:11) • "you seek ... the one who seeks" (7:7-8)
Comparing Matthew 6:19-7:11. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).	

Loving God With Our Wealth

New Covenant Righteousness and Wealth

A - Matthew 6:19-21 Don't store up wealth on the land, rather store up in the wealth in the skies
B - Matthew 6:22-23 Parable about two eyes: the genuine-and-generous eye or the bad-greedy eye
B' - Matthew 6:24 Parable about two masters: God or <i>mammon</i>
A' - Matthew 6:25-34

Don't worry about food and clothing,
rather trust your **Father in the skies**

Matthew 6:19-34. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Two Kinds of Wealth, Two Kinds of Master

- A a ¹⁹ Don't **store up** (θησαυρίζετε) for yourselves **stored-wealth** (θησαυρούς) **on the land** ,
b **where** moth and nibbler can ruin,
c and **where** thieves break in and steal.

- A' a ²⁰ But **store up** (θησαυρίζετε) for yourselves **stored-wealth** (θησαυρούς) **in the sky** ,
b **where** neither moth nor nibbler can ruin,
c and **where** thieves do not break in or steal;

- B d ²¹ for **where** your **stored-wealth** is,
there your heart will be also.

- A 22 The **lamp** of **the body** is **the eye**;
so then if **your eye** is genuine-and-generous,
your **whole body** will be **radiant** .

- B 23 But if **your eye** is bad-and-greedy,
your whole body will be **dark** .

- A' **If then** the **light** that is in you is **darkness** ,
how great is the **darkness** !

- A 24 **No one is able to serve** **two masters** ;

- a for either he will **hate the one**
and **love the other** ,

ב' or he will be devoted to one
א' and despise the other .

A You are not able to serve God and wealth .

Matthew 6:19-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Stored Wealth on Heaven and Earth

In a day before bank accounts, the storage of wealth or “treasure” was an obvious challenge of daily life.

“In a culture where banking was embryonic and little used or trusted (see Jesus’ parable of the talents in [25:25–27](#)), ‘treasures’ were normally kept in goods or hard currency in the home or in a supposedly safe place. ... They were thus liable to physical deterioration or theft, and the insecurity of material goods is a recurrent theme of the wisdom writers (see [Prov. 23:4–5](#), [27:24](#); [Eccles. 5:13–17](#)); for the role of the ‘moth’ in this cf. [Ps. 39:11](#); [Job 13:28](#). Equally obvious is the fact that however carefully material wealth may be preserved, it is of no use beyond this life on earth. ... In place of such dubious acquisitions, ‘treasures in heaven’ are a much more desirable alternative. ... The nature of these heavenly treasures is not spelled out here, but later in the gospel we shall hear of ‘inheriting eternal life’ as the compensation for loss of earthly advantages (19:27–29; cf. 16:25–26), of ‘entering the master’s joy’ ([25:21, 23](#)) and of ‘inheriting the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world’ (25:34), which is further identified as ‘eternal life’ ([25:46](#)). ‘Heaven’ can of course serve as a surrogate for the name of God (as in “the kingdom of heaven” and e.g., in [21:25](#)), so that ‘treasures in heaven’ might be taken to mean ‘treasures with God’ rather than referring specifically to a future life, but here the direct contrast with ‘on earth’ and the sense of provision for the future implied in ‘store up for yourselves’ strongly suggest an other-worldly focus.”

France, R. T. (2007). [The Gospel of Matthew \(The New International Commentary on the New Testament\)](#). Eerdmans. 258.

France makes many good points. Wealth only serves us in this life, so don’t give it more weight than it is due; it’s very fragile.

The nature of the “heavenly wealth” is not spelled out, but elsewhere in Jesus’ teaching it is described as “inheriting eternal life,” “entering the master’s joy,” and “inheriting the kingdom.” “Heaven” is often a swappable term in place of “God,” so that having “treasure in heaven” can equal the reward of God’s presence itself.

“Moth and Nibbler”

“The eater” (Greek: *brosis* / βρῶσις), literally “consumables, food.” This is a general word for food that is similar to our English word “edible,” meaning “that which is subject to being eaten.” Here, in Jesus’ figure of speech, it refers to any possession which is vulnerable to being eaten by the typical cast of creatures: insects, rodents, etc.

Many modern translations recognize that this word has another nuance of meaning that feels like the opposite of “edible,” since *broxis* can also describe a creature who is doing the eating:

Matthew 6:19 NIV

Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and **vermin** destroy, and where thieves break in and steal.

Matthew 6:19 NET

Do not accumulate for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and **devouring insect** destroy and where thieves break in and steal.

Matthew 6:19 LEB

Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and **consuming insect** destroy and where thieves break in and steal,

This nuance of meaning is found in the Septuagint of Malachi 3:11 to refer to locusts eating grain stores.

Malachi 3:10–11 NIV*

“Bring the whole tithe into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house. Test me in this,” says the Lord Almighty, “and see if I will not throw open the floodgates of heaven and pour out so much blessing that there will not be room enough to store it.

I will prevent **pests** (Septuagint: *broxis*) from devouring your crops, and the vines in your fields will not drop their fruit before it is ripe,” says the Lord Almighty.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Older English translations have the rendering “rust,” which comes from the influence of the parallel passage in James 5:2-3 (moth and rust, Greek: *ios* / *ιος*) and from old Latin translation, the Vulgate, which translated *broxis* as *erugo*, meaning “rust.”

Moth (Greek: *ses* / *σης*): Moths were associated with destroying clothing, especially clothing that is being stored and currently unworn.

Psalms 39:11 NASB

When you rebuke and discipline anyone for their sin, **you consume their wealth like a moth—**surely everyone is but a breath.

Isaiah 50:9 NASB

Behold, the Lord God helps me;
Who is he who condemns me?
Behold, they will all wear out **like a garment;**
the moth will eat them.

Isaiah 51:8 NASB

“For **the moth will eat them like a garment,**
and the grub will eat them like wool.

But my righteousness will be forever,
And my salvation to all generations.”

Job 13:28 NASB

While I am decaying like a rotten thing,
like a garment that is moth-eaten.

Epistle of Jeremiah v. 12

“They dress up their idols in clothes like human beings—gods of **silver and gold and wood!**
12 Although **draped in purple clothes**, these gods **cannot save themselves from rust and moths.**”

Moore, Carey A. (1995). [*Daniel, Esther, and Jeremiah: The Additions \(The Anchor Yale Bible\)*](#). Yale University Press. 337.

James 5:1–3 NASB

Come now, you rich, weep and howl for your miseries which are coming upon you.
Your riches have rotted and your garments have become **moth-eaten**.
Your gold and your silver have **rusted**; and their **rust** will be a witness against you and will consume your flesh like fire. It is in the last days that you have stored up your treasure!

“Treasure in the Skies”

“Treasure in the skies” was a common theme in Second Temple literature, developed out of the hope that God had an Eden-like existence in store for all of creation in the future, which would have a totally different economy.

References to this new creation treasure abound.

Tobit 4:8–9 NRSVCE

If you have many possessions, make your gift from them in proportion; if few, do not be afraid to give according to the little you have. **So you will be laying up a good treasure for yourself against the day of necessity.**

Psalms of Solomon 9:5 NRSVCE

He that does righteousness **lays up** (θησαυρίζει) **for himself life with the Lord**

2 Baruch 14:12 NRSVCE

For the righteous justly have good hope for the end
and go away from this habitation without fear
because **they possess with you a store of good works which is preserved in treasures.**

2 Baruch 24:1 NRSVCE

For behold, the days are coming, and the books will be opened in which are written the sins of all those who have sinned, and moreover, also **the treasures in which are brought together the righteousness of all those who have proven themselves to be righteous.**

Wisdom of Ben Sira 29:10-12 NRSVCE

Lose your silver for the sake of a brother or a friend,
and do not let it rust under a stone and be lost.
Lay up your treasure according to the commandments of the Most High,
and it will profit you more than gold.
Store up almsgiving in your treasury,
and it will rescue you from every disaster;

Jesus elsewhere elaborates on this “heavenly reward” for losses suffered on earth, but not in a way that gives us any kind of “literal” explanation.

Matthew 19:16, 20–22 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ And someone came to him and said,
“Teacher, what good thing shall I do **that I may have eternal life?**” ...

²⁰ The young man said to him,
“All these things I have kept; what am I still lacking?”

²¹ Jesus said to him,
“If you wish to be complete,
**go and sell your possessions and give to the poor,
and you will have stored-wealth in the skies;**
and come, follow me.”

²² But when the young man heard this statement, he went away grieving;
for he was one who owned much property.

Matthew 25:21 LEB

His master said to him,
“Well done, good and faithful slave!
You were faithful over a few things;
I will put you in charge over many things.
Enter into the joy of your master!”

Matthew 19:28–29 NASB

And Jesus said to them,
“Truly I say to you, that you who have followed me,
in the rebirthing, when the Son of Man will sit on his glorious throne,
you also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.
And everyone who has left houses or brothers or sisters or father or mother or children or farms,
for my name’s sake,
**they will receive many times as much,
and they will inherit eternal life.”**

Matthew 25:34 LEB

Then the king will say to those on his right,
"Come, you who are blessed by my Father.

Inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world!"

"[W]hile the theme of reward is important in this gospel, we must remind ourselves again that in the parable which most directly addresses the issue (20:1–15) there is a deliberate discrepancy between the effort expended and the recompense received: God does not leave anyone unfairly treated, but his grace is not limited to human deserving. In a kingdom in which the first are last and the last first (19:30; 20:16) there is no room for computing one's 'treasures in heaven' on the basis of earthly effort. Those treasures are 'stored up' not by performing meritorious acts (and certainly not only by alms-giving) but by belonging to and living by the priorities of the kingdom of heaven."

France, R. T. (2007). [*The Gospel of Matthew \(The New International Commentary on the New Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans. 259.

Matthew 20:10–15 NIV

¹⁰ So when those came who were hired first, they expected to receive more. But each one of them also received a denarius.

¹¹ When they received it, they began to grumble against the landowner.

¹² "These who were hired last worked only one hour," they said, "and you have made them equal to us, who have borne the burden of the work and the heat of the day."

¹³ "But he answered one of them, "I am not doing you wrong, friend. Didn't you agree to work for a denarius?"

¹⁴ Take your pay and go. I desire to give the one who was hired last the same as I gave you.

¹⁵ Don't I have the right to do what I desire with what is mine? **Or is your eye bad because I am good?"**

In this sense, Jesus' teaching is similar to that of Paul, who develops the heavenly treasure image.

1 Timothy 6:17–19 NIV

Command those who are rich in this present world not to be arrogant nor to put their hope in wealth, which is so uncertain, but to put their hope in God, who richly provides us with everything for our enjoyment.

Command them to do good, to be rich in good deeds, and to be generous and willing to share.

In this way **they will lay up treasure for themselves as a firm foundation for the coming age**, so that they may take hold of the life that is truly life.

It's probably worth noting that Jesus is not here commanding poverty or the itinerant life for all of his disciples. He elsewhere counsels the strategic use of wealth for navigating life in this world.

Luke 16:9–13 LEB

⁹ And I tell you, **make friends for yourselves by means of unrighteous mammon**, so that when it runs out they will welcome you into the eternal dwellings.

¹⁰ The one who is faithful in very little is also faithful in much, and the one who is dishonest in very little is also dishonest in much. ¹¹ If then you have not been faithful with unrighteous wealth (lit. *mammona*), who will entrust to you the true riches? ¹² And if you have not been faithful with what belongs to another, who

will give you your own?

¹³ No domestic slave is able to serve two masters, for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to one and will despise the other. You are not able to serve God and *mammon*.

The Lamp of the Body

The basic idea of this short riddle seems clear-ish on a first reading. Our eyes are like a window into our body, which can lead to inner light or darkness, but also leads to that inner light or darkness radiating out as well.

But how does this metaphor work, actually? And why is Jesus bringing up eyes at all in a section of teaching on wealth and generosity?

There is an important clue in the word Jesus uses to describe the “good” eye in contrast to a “bad” eye.

Matthew 6:22-23 Instructor's Translation

²² “If, however, your eye is **haplous** (Greek ἀπλοῦς) ...

²³ But if your eye is **poneros** (Greek πονηρός) ...

This rare Greek word *haplous* is used only here and in the parallel saying in [Luke 11:34](#). The root word is *haplous* (Greek ἀπλός), which in [Liddell-Scott's Lexicon](#) has the following nuances of meaning:

1. “single”
2. “simple, plain, straightforward”
3. “simple, as in whole, unmixed,” the opposite of διπλᾶ “two-fold” or “divided”

The word *haplous* means “whole,” with the meaning of “whole and uncompromised” (equivalent to “complete” *teleios* in [5:48](#)). Our English word “genuine” is a good rendering.

The word *haplous* can stand in contrast to “bad” in [6:23](#). So, by inference, it can also mean “a good eye,” which is a figure of speech for “generous,” as discussed below.

The noun related to this root occurs often in the New Testament, *hoplotes*, which can mean “simplicity, sincerity” ([Eph. 6:5](#); [Col. 3:22](#); [2 Cor. 1:12](#)), or also “generosity”.

Romans 12:8 NASB*

Let the one who gives, give with **hoplotes**

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Corinthians 8:2 NASB*

their abundance of joy and their deep poverty overflowed in the wealth of their **hoplotes**

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Corinthians 9:11 NASB*

you will be enriched in all things with **hoplotes**, producing gratefulness to God

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

James 1:5 NASB*

If any of you lacks wisdom, let them ask God who gives **haplos** ... and it will be given to him

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

This meaning of *hoplotes* as “generous” is the binary opposite of “a bad eye” in biblical Hebrew idiom (*ra’ ayin*), meaning “jealous stinginess,” and is related to “good eye” (*tov ayin*), meaning generosity.”

Proverbs 22:9 Instructor's Translation

He who is **good of eye** will be blessed, for he gives some of his food to the poor.

Proverbs 23:6–7 NASB

Do not eat the bread of one with **a bad eye**, or desire his delicacies;
For as he thinks within himself, so he is.
He says to you, “Eat and drink!”
But his heart is not with you.

Proverbs 28:22 NASB

A man with **a bad eye** hastens after wealth
And does not know that want will come upon him.

Jesus himself uses the phrase “bad eye” for “stinginess” later in his parable of the delayed laborers.

Matthew 20:15 Instructor's Translation

Is it not lawful for me to do what I wish with what is my own? Or is your **eye bad** because I am generous?

Mark 7:21–22 Instructor's Translation

For from within, out of the heart of men, proceed the evil thoughts, fornications, thefts, murders, adulteries, deeds of coveting and wickedness, as well as deceit, sensuality, **a bad eye (“envy”)**, slander, pride and foolishness.

Jesus is using the common binary phrase of the “good eye” or the “bad eye” as figures of speech for generosity or stinginess. But instead of using the phrase “good eye,” we find *haplous*, which means “genuine, sincere,” as an image of focused generosity.

The Eye is the Lamp of the Body

The “eye as a lamp” metaphor is developed out of a common figure of speech in biblical and later Jewish literature:

- The “light of the eyes” is a mark of happiness. (Prov. 15:30 “Light of the eyes brings joy to the heart”)
- Eyes being enlightened or darkened can be a mark of life and vigor or decline and death.
 - The weary Jonathan’s eyes “brighten” when he tastes honey (1 Sam. 14:27).
 - Ezra asks God to “enlighten our eyes and grant us a little reviving in our bondage” (Ezra 9:8).
 - The eyes of divine beings are sometimes described as lamps that shine light out as they look (Dan. 10:6; Zech. 4:2, 10).

Daniel 10:5–6 NASB

I lifted my eyes and looked, and behold, there was a certain man dressed in linen, whose waist was girded with a belt of pure gold of Uphaz. His body also was like beryl, his face had the appearance of lightning, **his eyes were like flaming torches**, his arms and feet like the gleam of polished bronze, and the sound of his words like the sound of a tumult.

Zechariah 4:1–2 NASB

Then the angel who was speaking with me returned and roused me, as a man who is awakened from his sleep. He said to me, “What do you see?” And I said, “I see, and behold, a lampstand all of gold with its bowl on the top of it, and **its seven lamps on it** with seven spouts belonging to each of the lamps which are on the top of it;

Zechariah 4:10 NASB

... But these seven will be glad when they see the plumb line in the hand of Zerubbabel—**these are the eyes of the LORD** which range to and fro throughout the earth.

Psalms 38:10 NASB

My heart throbs, my strength fails me;
and **the light of my eyes, even that has gone from me.**

The image is strange to us because the “eye is a lamp” metaphor makes one think the eye is a source of light that shines out into the world, making one’s path clear. But that’s not quite what Jesus goes on to say. He rather makes the body the location of light or darkness, as if the eye is some kind of translucent conduit of light or dark.

This has led to two views about the relationship between the light and the eye in this saying of Jesus, and scholars turn to ancient sources to figure out which view was more widely held in the ancient world.

1. The extramission view: The eyes shine out light based on an inner source of light and vitality.
2. The intramission view: The eyes are a conduit for external light/darkness that enters and thus affects one’s well-being.

“[C]ommentators have not been able to agree on how the image works here in relation to the body. A common view that the eye is the “window” through which light enters the body suggests the surprising notion that light is needed inside the body. Or the idea might be that our awareness of light around us comes through the eye, but ‘lamp’ is not the most obvious way to say that. The lamp metaphor more naturally suggests the function of the eye in providing the light which shows the body the way to go, but the following adjectives (light/dark) indicate that it’s the body itself, not its surroundings, which is either ‘illuminated’ or ‘in the dark’ depending on how well the eye functions—see the final comment on ‘the light which is in you’ being darkness. Perhaps we can be no more definite than to say that the imagery depends on light being necessary for the proper functioning of the body (person) and that this light is in some way dependent on the condition of the eye.”

France, R. T. (2007). [*The Gospel of Matthew \(The New International Commentary on the New Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans. 260-261.

“[W]ithin Matthew’s usage one could argue that the strong internal/external person theme is at play here with the idea that the light or darkness inside of a person comes out in one’s actions (being generous or greedy); even as Jesus says elsewhere, it is what is already inside a person, not what goes in, that defiles him or her because this is where the heart is (Matt. 15:10-20). This would accord with the extramission view. On the other hand, one could argue that the way the eye metaphor works in Matt. 6:22-23 is that one’s actions (generous versus stingy) create in us light or darkness, based on the wording ‘will be light/darkness.’ This would be an intromission understanding. ... [T]here is wisdom in not getting stuck in this debate, recognizing that either way the point is that the eye is a metaphorical window between the inside and the outside of a person. This is clearly a major ... theme [in the sermon]—the organic connection between the inside and the outside of the person and the necessity of integration/wholeness for true righteousness.”

Pennington, Jonathan (2017). [The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing](#). Baker Academic. 241.

“Pre-modern people tended to believe that the eyes contain a fire or light, and that this fire or light is what makes sight possible. ... Ancient Jews were no exception. They spoke of ‘the light of the eyes’ (Prov. 15:30 MT; Tob. 10:5; 11:13), of eyes becoming dimmed or darkened (Gen. 27:1, 48:10; Deut. 34:7; Lam. 5:17; T. Benj. 4:2; Josephus, Ant. 8:268; b. Ber. 16b), and of God ‘enlightening’ or ‘brightening’ the eyes (Ezra 9:8; Bar. 1:12; cf. 1 Sam. 14:24–30 MT; T. Gad. 5:7; b. Yeb. 63a; b. Meg. 12b). They imagined that the eye was like the sun, both being senders of rays (2 Sam. 12:11; Ecclus. 23:19; 3 Bar. 8; Jos. Asen. 14:9), and they told stories in which the light or fire of the eyes actually became so intense that it was visible (Dan. 10:6; Rev. 1:14, 2:18, 19:12; 1 En. 106:2, 5, 10; 2 En. 1:5; 3 En 1:7–8; 9:4; 25:2–3, 6–7; Par. Jer. 7:3; b. B. Meṣ. 59b; b. Šabb. 33b).”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)](#). T&T Clark International. 635.

“A lamp is not a medium through which light from another source is channeled to an otherwise dark place. A lamp is rather its own source of light. From this alone it follows that the eye/lamp comparison would be natural only for one holding an extramission theory of vision. In line with this, in the six Jewish texts which liken the eye to a lamp, namely, in Dan. 10:6; Zech. 4; T. Job 18:3; 2 En. 42:1A; 3 En. 35:2; and b. Šabb. 151b, the comparison never has to do with the eye conveying light to the inward parts. On the contrary, in all six instances it is used to create the picture of a light coming forth from the eye.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)](#). T&T Clark International. 635-636.

“C. C. Torrey made sense of the words by arguing for an Aramaic original that was imperfectly translated into Greek. According to him, Jesus himself said, ‘If however your whole body is lighted up with no part dark, then all about you will be light, just as the lamp lights you with its brightness’ (Four Gospels, p. 309-10). The key to this reconstruction is the supposition that *ἔσται φωτεινὸν ὅλον* renders (incorrectly) *nahir leh’we kōllā*. This last word, rendered correctly as the adjective in the first clause, is here unquestionably the noun, ‘the whole, everything’. ‘The man who is full of light lights the world about him’ (*ibid*). Now it is hardly possible to show beyond reasonable doubt that Torrey—who was followed by Manson, Sayings (Sayings, pp. 93–4)—was correct in his conjecture. Nevertheless the result is a sentence which recalls other lines in the Jesus tradition (e.g. Mt. 5:14–16 and Gos. Thom. 24). So Torrey may very well have been on the mark. If so, then at least the earliest interpreter of the saying about the eye as lamp, that is, the author of

Lk. 11:36, understood Jesus' words in terms of the extramission theory of vision. This is so because it is natural to judge the sentence, 'If however your whole body is lighted up with no part dark, then all about you will be light,' as an extension of the 'eye as lamp metaphor.' Just as the healthy, good eye sends light into the world, so too do the righteous, filled with the light of God, dispel the shades around them. They are like a lamp that gives light to its environment. Which is to say: the picture is not of light coming in but of light going out. (5) Clement of Alexandria seems to have read our passage as involving the extramission theory of vision. In Paed. 3:11:70 there is this: 'the lamp of the body is the eye, Scripture says, δι' οὗ καταφαίνεται τὰ ἔνδον φωτὶ τῷ φαινομένῳ καταυγάζόμενα'." Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)](#). T&T Clark International. 636-637.

"[I]t seems likely that this saying is meant to indicate that one indication of a person's spiritual health is their generosity or lack of it in the use of their material possessions. So this rather obscure little saying seems to be using a word-play, which the English translator cannot reproduce without extensive paraphrase, in order to commend both single-mindedness (in pursuing the values of the kingdom of heaven) and generosity ... as a key to the effective life of a disciple."

France, R. T. (2007). [The Gospel of Matthew \(The New International Commentary on the New Testament\)](#). Eerdmans. 262.

God and Mammon

A 24 **No one is able to serve** **two masters** ;

B
 a for either he will **hate the one**
 b and **love the other** ,
 b' or he will be **devoted to one**
 a' and **despise the other** .

A **You are not able to serve** **God and** **wealth** .

Matthew 6:19-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

The word translated as "wealth" is an Aramaic word spelled in Greek *mammona* (μαμωνᾶ) which equals the Aramaic מַמְוֹן from מַאמְוֹן. Why Matthew chose to transliterate an Aramaic word here instead of providing a Greek equivalent is not clear. It could have been a popular oral saying in early Christian circles that he wanted to preserve in original form, or it could be to retain the personification aspect of the word, so that *mammon* is pitted against God himself.

Mammon “probably is a maqtāl form of the root ’amen (אמן) with the meaning of ‘that in which one puts trust’, with ‘money, riches’ as a derivative meaning. ... [In Jesus’ teaching] Mammon is personified as an evil and superhuman power that stands in competition to God and by possessing people can even keep them from being devoted to God and make them hate Him.”

van der Horst, P. W. (1999). “Mammon,” [Dictionary of Deities and Demons in the Bible](#). Wm. B. Eerdmans Publishing Co. 542.

Jesus uses the word *mammona* one other time, the parallel saying in Luke 16:11, followed by the parable about the shrewd manager:

Luke 16:10–11 Instructor's Translation

He who is faithful in a very little thing is faithful also in much; and he who is unrighteous in a very little thing is unrighteous also in much. Therefore if you have not been faithful in the use of unrighteous **mammona**, who will entrust the true riches to you?

In this second usage of the word, Jesus does not personify *mammona*, which should perhaps make us hesitate to conclude that *mammona* is an actual spiritual being in Jesus’ imagination. Rather, Jesus personifies *mammona* in order to depict its power over the human will and mind.

“[T]he point is ... that one cannot serve two masters well, giving each his due, because their demands will not always be compatible. This is true above all when the masters are God and mammon. For God, who demands self-sacrifice, commands an exclusive allegiance and obligation which must transcend all other claimants for a person’s soul; while mammon, once it has its hooks in human flesh, will drag it where it wills, all the time whispering into the ear dreams of self-aggrandizement. The marching orders of God and of mammon are in entirely different directions.”

Davies, W. D. & Allison Jr., Dale C. (2004). [Matthew, vol. 1 \(International Critical Commentary\)](#). T&T Clark International. 641-642.

There are many texts in the Hebrew Bible that contrast one’s trust in wealth with one’s trust in God (see [Ps. 49](#) and [Ps. 52](#)).

Reflection Question

What does Jesus mean when he says to “store up for yourselves stored-wealth in the sky”?